Developing staff capability for inclusive EMI

Practical guide for institutions | I05

Build sustained professional development that helps staff teach and support students learning through English. EMI development should address teaching practice and communication as well as English proficiency, while maintaining disciplinary outcomes and standards.

Using this guide: Use existing staff development and teaching-quality processes. I04 addresses individual educators' development needs and support pathways; this guide addresses how the institution organises, resources and reviews provision across teams.

1. Set priorities from teaching and support needs

Assign a staff development lead to use findings from I04, course review and student feedback to agree shared priorities with program teams. Include subject educators, language specialists and staff who advise students or manage learning resources. Confirm the budget, staff time and responsibility for delivery.

Priorities might include clearer explanations, purposeful group participation, accessible assessment guidance or support for expressing disciplinary reasoning. Distinguish development needs from problems requiring more time, staffing or resources.

2. Design development around actual practice

Use course materials and upcoming teaching tasks rather than relying only on general presentations about EMI. Ask participants to revise a brief, rehearse an explanation or plan a way to check understanding.

Include relevant English-language development where needed, but do not assume a general English course will address teaching design or interaction. Provide different routes for staff with different experience and responsibilities.

3. Plan learning followed by classroom application

Organise a development sequence that combines a focused session with supported preparation, a classroom trial and a review. Allocate time for each stage and access to feedback. Agree what participants will try and what evidence will help them judge whether it helped.

For example, an educator revises a lecture explanation with a colleague, trials a short understanding check and reviews student responses. Peer observation or rehearsal should have an agreed developmental purpose and feedback arrangements.

4. 4. Resource collaboration between specialists

Give subject educators and language specialists time to examine disciplinary tasks together. Subject educators contribute disciplinary judgement; language specialists help identify language demands and ways to support them.

Prepare language specialists for this work too, including opportunities to understand disciplinary genres and assessment expectations. Name a coordinator, allocate time and provide access to relevant materials. Do not rely solely on voluntary work outside normal responsibilities.

5. Include ethnic-minority languages and experiences

Help staff recognise students' varied language repertoires and avoid assumptions based on ethnicity, accent or silence. Vietnamese may be useful, but it is not necessarily every student's strongest language.

Include supported practice in planning multilingual activities and checking meaning within institutional development provision. Prepare staff to include students who do not share a language. Staff do not need to learn every student's language, and students should not be expected to represent a community or interpret sensitive information for peers.

6. Review application and sustain useful provision

Check whether staff could apply the learning, what changed in teaching or support, and what further help is needed. Attendance and satisfaction alone do not establish improved practice or student learning.

Use useful examples in later induction and peer learning, with permission and appropriate anonymisation. Offer follow-up coaching or specialist input and address institutional barriers identified through the trials.

7. Example organising development to improve participation

Several course teams report that discussions are dominated by a few confident speakers. The faculty development lead agrees a shared priority, allocates preparation and follow-up time, and arranges collaboration with a language specialist. Teams use upcoming disciplinary problems to plan participation.

Educators rehearse and trial the activities with specialist feedback. The development lead reviews whether teams could apply the learning, what students experienced and what further support is needed. Useful examples inform induction and later development; barriers requiring additional resources go to the responsible institutional lead.

8. Review checklist

☐ Priorities reflect actual teaching and support needs.

☐ Provision addresses pedagogy, communication and relevant language development.

☐ Participants practise and apply learning to course tasks.

☐ Development, collaboration and follow-up have a named lead, budget and allocated time.

☐ Ethnic-minority languages and varied student experiences are considered.

☐ Review examines application and student experience as well as attendance.

9. When further institutional action is needed

Provide individual language development, specialist teaching support or sustained coaching where a shared activity is insufficient. Escalate unavailable staffing, preparation time or resources through institutional processes; repeated workshops cannot resolve every barrier.

10.Related toolkit guidance

I04: identifying educators' needs. I01: program review. I06: resource access. I08: monitoring. Educator practical guides provide examples for classroom trials.

11.Supporting sources

Galloway, N. (Ed.). (2020). English in higher education – English medium. Part 1: Literature review. British Council. Open source

Pages 50–54 discuss pedagogy, communication and language skills, continuing development and institutional support. The guide's trial-and-review sequence is a toolkit adaptation.

Galloway, N., & Sahan, K. (2021). An investigation into English Medium Instruction in higher education in Thailand and Vietnam. British Council. Open source

Section 9, "Teacher recruitment and training" (p. 42), discusses tailored preparation for subject and language educators and clearer roles; p. 44 discusses communities of practice.

The steps, example and checklist are toolkit adaptations for Vietnamese higher education. Sources support particular principles rather than the complete guide. The focus on ethnic-minority students and languages requires local consultation and evaluation. Developing draft for review; this is not a validated assessment or audit instrument.